

Unit Y302: The Viking Age c.790–1066

This theme focuses on the development of Viking Scandinavia and Viking overseas expansion. Learners should consider both the reasons for and extent of political, religious, economic, social and cultural change that ensued as a result of Viking raids and settlement. Learners should consider how far, and for what reasons, this relationship changed. The strands

identified below are not to be studied in isolation to each other.

Learners are not expected to demonstrate a detailed understanding of the specification content, except for the named in-depth studies, but are expected to know the main developments and turning points relevant to the theme.

Thematic Study: The Viking Age c.790–1066	
Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
Viking society, administration and livelihood	Viking identity; Scandinavian land and climate; Scandinavian society (including slaves, the free, women, children, elites and rules of conduct); Scandinavian administration; accession to the throne and personal power; royal power (kingship); political developments in Denmark, Norway and Sweden; Scandinavian livelihood (including trade, developments in shipbuilding, seafaring, money, farming, hunting and craft-working).
Warfare and raids	Raids on England and Scotland; motives for raids; the destruction of monasteries (including Lindisfarne and Iona); the stimulus for Scottish unity; the 860s as a possible turning point; Alfred's and Athelstan's response to raids; relative peace after 955; the 'second Viking age' and Danegeld; conquest; decline and fall; expansionism: motives (economic, political and social); raiding and trading in Ireland, Wales, the Isle of Man, the Carolingian Empire (including Normandy and Brittany), Russia, Byzantium, Iceland and Greenland.
Settlements	Scandinavian rural and urban settlements; English rural and urban settlements (including York); the Danelaw; kingship; the impact of settlements on livelihood (including farming, craft-working, trade); society (including social structure, families, kinship and customs); the move towards a united English kingdom; settlements in Western and Eastern Europe including parts of the Carolingian Empire and the Iberian Peninsula.
Culture and religion	Religious belief; old religion, the gods (including Odin, Thor, Frey and the Norns), outdoor worship (including ship-settings), sacrificial sites, burial customs; new religion: Christianisation (including the conversion of Harald Bluetooth and Denmark c.965, Harald's Jelling monuments, the conversion of Olaf Trygvason and Norway c.995), new rituals and codes of conduct; culture: art (decorative and pictorial), language, writing (including runes), and naming customs; poetry and its purpose (including rune poems, eddaic poems and skaldic verse), sagas; dress, jewellery; feasting.

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Depth studies	Content Learners should be aware of debates surrounding the issues outlined for each in-depth topic:
Raids on England in the late eighth and ninth centuries	Motives; the impact on Anglo-Saxon politics, the economy, culture and society (including religious belief); the significance of the 860s ('a great heathen army'); the response to raids; the first settlements.
The Danelaw	Definitions, origins (links with raids); organisation; growth; response from Anglo-Saxons (relationships between inhabitants and colonists); the impact on the northern and eastern economy, society (the creation of a distinctive Viking society), culture, religion and politics; the importance of York.
The Vikings in Ireland	Motives for raiding, trading and settlement; phases of involvement and links to Viking activity elsewhere; the impact on the Irish economy (including trade), society (including religion), culture and politics; areas of settlement (including the origins and growth of Viking Dublin).